

MAINCRAFTS TECHNOLOGY

Cybersecurity & Ethical Hacking
Internship Program

TASK – 1 Cybersecurity Threat Intelligence Report (2024-2025)

Awareness & Reasearch Project

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Date : 9 july 2026

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1. Introduction to Cybersecurity

What is Cybersecurity?

Cybersecurity is the practice of protecting computer systems, networks, applications, and data from unauthorized access, damage, theft, or disruption. It encompasses a broad set of technologies, processes, and controls — including firewalls, encryption, access management, and security monitoring — designed to safeguard the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of digital information (commonly referred to as the CIA triad). As organizations and individuals rely increasingly on digital infrastructure, cybersecurity has evolved from a purely technical concern into a core business and personal safety requirement.

Why Is It Important for Individuals and Businesses?

For individuals, cybersecurity protects personal identity, financial accounts, and private communications from theft and misuse. A single compromised password or a successful phishing email can lead to drained bank accounts, identity fraud, or blackmail. For businesses, the stakes are even higher: a breach can result in the loss of sensitive customer and intellectual property data, prolonged operational downtime, regulatory penalties under laws such as GDPR and India's DPDP Act, and long-term reputational damage that erodes customer trust. In sectors such as healthcare, finance, and critical infrastructure, a cyberattack can even endanger human safety.

Current Relevance

The threat landscape has intensified sharply in 2024–2025. Global cybercrime costs are projected to reach trillions of dollars annually, driven by the rapid digitization of business, the proliferation of connected (IoT) devices, and growing reliance on cloud services. A defining trend of this period is the weaponization of artificial intelligence — attackers now use generative AI to craft hyper-personalized phishing messages, clone voices and faces for deepfake fraud, and automate vulnerability discovery, while ransomware has evolved into a full-fledged criminal-service industry. At the same time, defenders are adopting AI-driven detection, Zero Trust architectures, and continuous threat intelligence to keep pace.

2. AI-Powered Phishing Attacks

Emails, Deepfakes & AI-Driven Social Engineering

Overview

AI-powered phishing uses generative AI and machine learning to craft highly convincing, personalized phishing emails, voice calls, and even real-time video deepfakes. Unlike traditional phishing, which relied on generic messages riddled with grammatical errors, AI-generated lures mimic writing styles, reference real organizational details, and can clone a colleague's or executive's voice and likeness from just a few seconds of public audio or video, making detection far harder for both employees and automated filters.

Impact Analysis

Impact on Individuals

- Victims can be tricked into revealing banking credentials, OTPs, or personal identification details.
- AI-cloned voices of family members are increasingly used in emergency-scam calls to extort money.

Real-World Case Study: Arup Engineering Deepfake Video-Call Fraud (2024)

In February 2024, a finance employee at Arup, the UK-based multinational engineering firm behind projects such as the Sydney Opera House, was targeted by a sophisticated scam. After receiving a phishing message impersonating the CFO, the employee joined a video conference in which every other participant — including a convincing likeness of the CFO and other senior leaders — was an AI-generated deepfake. Convinced by the realistic audio and video, the employee authorized fifteen transactions totaling approximately USD 25 million to accounts controlled by the attackers. The incident is widely regarded as one of the most damaging deepfake-enabled corporate frauds to date and demonstrates how AI has fundamentally changed the reliability of visual and voice verification.

Preventive Measures

- Implement Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) for all financial approval workflows.
- Establish out-of-band verification (a callback on a known number) for any unusual fund-transfer request, regardless of how convincing a call or video appears.

3. Ransomware-as-a-Service (RaaS)

Ransomware Kits Available to Criminals on Demand

Overview

Ransomware-as-a-Service is a criminal business model in which ransomware developers lease their malware and infrastructure to “affiliates” in exchange for a share of the ransom proceeds. This has drastically lowered the technical barrier to launching a ransomware attack, allowing even low-skilled criminals to rent ready-made encryption tools, negotiation portals, and data-leak sites. Modern RaaS operations increasingly favor “double extortion” — stealing data before encrypting it — so that victims face both operational disruption and the threat of public data leaks.

Impact Analysis

Impact on Individuals

- Personal medical, financial, and identity data can be exposed on criminal leak sites even if a ransom is paid.
- Victims of leaked data face elevated risk of follow-on identity theft and fraud.

Real-World Case Study: Change Healthcare / ALPHV-BlackCat Attack (February 2024)

In February 2024, the ALPHV/BlackCat ransomware-as-a-service group breached Change Healthcare, a UnitedHealth Group subsidiary that processes roughly 15 billion healthcare transactions annually. Attackers gained access through compromised credentials on a Citrix remote-access portal that lacked multi-factor authentication, then moved laterally for over a week before exfiltrating data and deploying ransomware. The breach disrupted claims processing and pharmacy operations nationwide, compromised the personal and health information of over 100 million individuals — making it the largest healthcare data breach in U.S. history — and led UnitedHealth to pay an estimated USD 22 million ransom, despite which stolen data was still threatened with a second extortion attempt by another group.

Preventive Measures

- Enforce Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) on all remote-access and privileged accounts.
- Maintain regular, tested, offline backups to enable recovery without paying ransom.
- Adopt a Zero Trust Security Model to limit lateral movement if credentials are compromised.

4. Cloud Security Misconfigurations

Data Leaks from AWS, GCP, and Azure Environments

Overview

As organizations migrate infrastructure to the cloud, improperly configured storage buckets, databases, and identity/access management (IAM) policies have become one of the leading causes of data breaches. Misconfigurations — such as publicly accessible storage, excessive permissions, or disabled encryption — often go undetected for months or years because cloud environments are complex, dynamic, and frequently lack continuous monitoring.

Impact Analysis

Impact on Individuals

- Personal data such as names, addresses, and vehicle or account identifiers can be exposed to anyone on the internet.
- Loss of control over how long private data remains publicly accessible, often without the individual's knowledge.

Real-World Case Study: Toyota Motor Cloud Misconfiguration (2023–2024)

Toyota disclosed that a misconfigured cloud environment left the personal data of approximately 2.15 million customers — including vehicle location information, customer IDs, and contact details — publicly accessible for nearly a decade, from November 2013 to April 2023. A follow-up investigation revealed a second, separate cloud misconfiguration exposing data of an additional 260,000 customers for over seven years. The root cause was identified as inadequate IAM policy enforcement and a lack of routine cloud security audits, illustrating how a single unnoticed setting can expose data for years without any active hacking taking place. Toyota subsequently implemented automated cloud-configuration monitoring across its environments.

Preventive Measures

- Perform regular cloud configuration audits using automated Cloud Security Posture Management (CSPM) tools.
- Apply the Principle of Least Privilege to all IAM roles and storage access permissions.
- Enable encryption at rest and in transit for all cloud-stored data, with continuous visibility across environments.

5. IoT (Internet of Things) Vulnerabilities

Smart Devices Being Hacked and Weaponized

Overview

IoT devices — smart cameras, routers, medical devices, and industrial sensors — are often shipped with weak default credentials, unpatched firmware, and minimal built-in security, making them attractive targets. Compromised IoT devices are frequently recruited into massive botnets used for distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) attacks, or exploited as an entry point into otherwise well-secured home and corporate networks.

Impact Analysis

Impact on Individuals

- Compromised routers can allow attackers to intercept traffic and steal personal data across a household network.
- Wearable and medical IoT devices, if breached, can expose sensitive health data or even be manipulated to cause harm.

Real-World Case Study: Mirai Botnet and Its Ongoing Variants

The Mirai botnet, first identified in 2016, scanned the internet for IoT devices such as routers and IP cameras still using factory-default usernames and passwords, then enslaved them into a botnet that launched some of the largest DDoS attacks recorded at the time, disrupting major DNS provider Dyn and taking down services including Twitter, Netflix, and Reddit for hours. Although the original operators were identified, Mirai's leaked source code continues to power new variants through 2024–2025, which are used by criminal groups to build rental “booter/stresser” services and to attack corporate and gaming infrastructure, showing how a single piece of poorly secured consumer hardware, multiplied across millions of devices, can threaten global internet stability.

Preventive Measures

- Change default IoT device credentials immediately upon setup and use strong, unique passwords.
- Keep IoT firmware updated and isolate IoT devices on a separate network segment (VLAN) from critical systems.

6. Zero-Day Exploits

Attacks on Unpatched, Previously Unknown Vulnerabilities

Overview

A zero-day exploit targets a software vulnerability that is unknown to the vendor and therefore has no available patch — giving defenders “zero days” of warning. Because signature-based defenses cannot detect an unknown flaw, zero-day attacks are especially valuable to sophisticated criminal and state-sponsored groups, who often use them to compromise widely-deployed enterprise software in a single coordinated campaign before a fix can be issued.

Impact Analysis

Impact on Individuals

- Individuals whose data is stored with any affected organization may have personal information stolen without any action of their own.

- Users of vulnerable consumer software may have devices compromised silently before a security update is released.
- Increased downstream risk of identity theft when exposed data circulates on criminal marketplaces.

Real-World Case Study: MOVEit Transfer Zero-Day Exploited by Clop (2023–2024)

In May 2023, the Clop ransomware group began exploiting a previously unknown SQL-injection vulnerability (CVE-2023-34362) in Progress Software's MOVEit Transfer file-sharing platform, days before a patch was available. Attackers deployed a custom web shell named LEMURLOOT to exfiltrate data from thousands of organizations worldwide, including government agencies, airlines, and universities. By the time remediation efforts concluded into 2024, the campaign had affected over 2,700 organizations and exposed the personal data of more than 93 million individuals, making it one of the largest single-vulnerability supply-chain incidents on record and a stark illustration of how one unpatched flaw in widely used software can cascade across an entire digital ecosystem.

Preventive Measures

- Maintain a rigorous patch-management program to apply vendor updates as soon as they are released.
- Deploy Intrusion Detection/Prevention Systems (IDS/IPS) and Web Application Firewalls (WAFs) to catch anomalous exploitation attempts.

7. Threat Summary at a Glance

The table below consolidates the five threats covered in this report alongside their primary attack vector, a representative case study, and the leading defense measure for each.

Threat	Primary Vector	Case Study	Key Defense
AI-Powered Phishing	Deepfake voice/video, personalized email	Arup (\$25M, 2024)	Out-of-band verification
Ransomware-as-a-Service	Compromised credentials, no MFA	Change Healthcare (2024)	MFA + offline backups
Cloud Misconfiguration	Public storage, weak IAM	Toyota (2013–2023)	CSPM audits + least privilege
IoT Vulnerabilities	Default credentials, unpatched firmware	Mirai Botnet	Credential hygiene + segmentation
Zero-Day Exploits	Unknown, unpatched software flaw	MOVEit / Clop (2023)	Patch management + IDS/IPS

8. Conclusion & Future Scope

The cybersecurity threats examined in this report — AI-powered phishing, Ransomware-as-a-Service, cloud misconfigurations, IoT vulnerabilities, and zero-day exploits — illustrate a threat landscape that is faster, more automated, and more deceptive than ever before. Each case study, from the \$25 million Arup deepfake fraud to the record-breaking MOVEit supply-chain breach, demonstrates that no organization is too large or too well-resourced to be affected. A recurring theme across all five threats is that the majority of breaches stem not from exotic technical wizardry alone, but from foundational lapses — missing MFA, unpatched software, misconfigured cloud storage, or default device passwords — combined with the increasing sophistication of AI-enabled attackers.

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